2.2 Educating and Advocating

When you see a situation that seems unjust, you want to do something about it. Likewise, positive changes in society have often started with one brave person raising his or her voice.

MAIN IDEA Reform movements in the 1830s and 1840s led to improvements in the treatment of mental illness, the prison system, and public education.

EDUCATION FOR ALL

If you were female, African American, or an immigrant, it was hard to get a good education in the United States during the early 19th century. To address the lack of education for girls and women, a number of women established schools for them, including Emma Willard, who founded the Troy Female Seminary in 1821, and Mary Lyon, who founded Mount Holyoke Female Seminary in 1837. Schools and colleges for girls and women were a step forward, but women's literacy rates were still half those of men. Further, most young people who attended school, whether male or female, came from wealthy families. Many lower-income, working-class, and immigrant children could not afford formal education. They chose work over school to help support their families.

African-American children faced other obstacles in education as well. Laws barred enslaved African Americans from studying at all, and free African Americans could only attend certain

CRITICAL VIEWING Primers were small books used in schools to teach beginning reading and arithmetic. This primer was printed on cloth and sewn together by a Boston printer around 1860. What do you notice about the illustrations used in this primer?



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schools. **Prudence Crandall,** an educator from Connecticut, took a bold step to address racism in education. When she opened the Canterbury School for young African-American girls in 1831, her small Connecticut town became the center of controversy. Crandall was arrested several times for unlicensed instruction, the school's water well was poisoned, and townspeople threw eggs and stones at her students. Crandall's school closed in 1834 after a violent mob broke windows and ransacked the classrooms. Clearly, racism against African Americans was not confined to the South.

Individuals and groups worked to correct these injustices and to reform the education system as a whole. The clear solution was to offer every American child a public education. Religious and women's groups campaigned for a public investment in education, or free public schools that would be funded by the collection of property taxes and managed by the local government. This education reform was known as the **common school movement**.

In 1837, **Horace Mann** put the ideas of the common school movement into action. Mann wanted the public education system to be rooted in good citizenship and moral education that would prepare students for society and the workforce. His crusade helped establish a public education system in Massachusetts for students of all social classes, genders, races, ethnicities, and faiths. Soon, other states followed. The Northeast took the lead in establishing free public schools, but the South lagged behind the rest of the nation for several decades.

REFORMING INSTITUTIONS

In the early 1800s, people knew little about what caused mental illnesses or how to treat them. A mental illness is a long-term disorder, such as depression or addiction, that alters one's personality or way of thinking. Those who suffered from such ailments were often feared and misunderstood. Many mentally ill patients ended up living in prisons or poorhouses.

A shocking visit to a prison inspired **Louis Dwight**, a minister from Massachusetts, to help the mentally ill. While visiting inmates, Dwight recognized the need to remove people with mental illnesses from prisons and place them in hospitals called **asylums**. Because of Dwight's efforts, Massachusetts General Hospital opened the state's first asylum at Worchester in 1833.

Dorothea Dix, a teacher from Maine, joined Dwight's cause in 1841 after witnessing mentally ill women shivering in an unheated jail cell. The authorities tried to convince her that, because they were mentally ill, the women could not feel the cold. After that visit, Dix toured hundreds of prisons, jails, and poorhouses. She persuaded state legislators to develop tax-supported systems of care. Her influence helped open more asylums.

At the same time, Dwight, Dix, and others called for improvements in the treatment of prisoners. They believed it was better to rehabilitate inmates, or restore them to health, instead of putting them in solitary confinement, where they were locked up with no human contact. Reformers cited tragedies from the past to make their case.

For instance, in 1821, wardens of Auburn Prison in New York had placed 80 prisoners into solitary confinement for long periods of time. Some prisoners were confined for their entire sentence, which caused many to become mentally ill. In the weeks following their release, many prisoners committed suicide. Soon after, Auburn Prison eliminated solitary confinement for prisoners. The Auburn Prison's change in policies supported the reformers' insistence that solitary confinement damaged prisoners. Reformers went on to fight for prison libraries and literacy classes, programs that can still be found in prisons today.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the common school movement address inequalities in education?
2. **MAKE CONNECTIONS** What connections do you see between the school system Horace Mann helped establish and today's schools?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** How did American reformers help mentally ill and imprisoned people in the 19th century?

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